

Romantic ideas

Many who claimed to possess military expertise had a notion of war far more romantic than realistic. Volunteer officers, such as Unionist Colonel Elmer Ellsworth, had more military knowledge than the average volunteer, and his interpretation of the tactics used by France's Zouave (North African) light infantry regiments—who were renowned as elite and disciplined fighters—reflected current and future military developments in infantry tactics. These included formations of troops trained to move quickly, spread out, and fire accurately. Nevertheless, Ellsworth did not fully understand these tactical evolutions.

Lack of trained officers

While the small number of military-age men with formal training at either West Point or various state military academies (the most important being the Virginia Military Institute) rose to instant prominence during the organization of the new armies, the sheer size of the forces and their democratic organization required most officers to come from civilian life.

In this phase of the war, before the rise of conscription, local leaders raised companies and regiments by personal influence (and sometimes even using their own money). In keeping with democratic practice, regiments also elected their officers. These volunteers thus tended to hold their roles by virtue of a whole range of factors unrelated to military competence, such as political influence, wealth, social standing, and simple popularity. As early as September 1861, one officer, Wilder Dwight of the 2nd Massachusetts, grumbled that “Today our army is crippled by the ideas of equality and independence which have covered the whole life of our people. Men elect their officers, and then expect them to behave themselves!” Such opinions were rare among his peers during the early part of the war.